

Posting Photographs

If you are a proud Web site owner, you might want to post images on your site. There is software available that helps you grab frames which can be used to take still shots with the aid of your Web cam. Webcam32 can also be used to grab still images. Set the focus of the camera on the object you want to take a low-resolution image of. Click on the 'Camera' icon in the main window of the software—this will throw open the Preferences window and point to the 'Capture' option. Click on 'Still Grab' if it's not selected. Your object is shown on the left-hand side of the window. Adjust the camera settings if necessary. Click on the 'Grab' button to take a photograph of the image and save the image on your hard disk in JPEG, BMP or PNG format. Now whenever you want a low-res image on your site, you know what to do.

adjustments can be tweaked using the software. Usually there are no controls on the camera except perhaps the latest combo models, which have a few buttons for recording video and clicking photographs.

Look world! Here I am

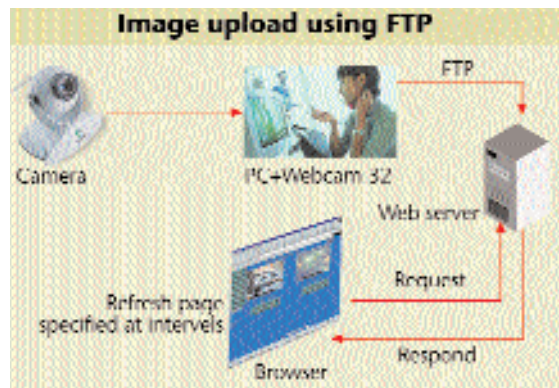
You might want to use the Web cam to let the Net world get a look at you, to monitor your house, check on the baby sitter while at work, and so on. In fact, if there is something that you would like to monitor remotely, then broadcasting via a Web camera is the best option. You can use certain software to capture the image from your camera at regular intervals and then upload it to your Web server. The principle is simple. Someone views a Web page on your site. The page has an image,

which is also located on the Web site. When you constantly update the image on the site and at the same time refresh the Web page the user is viewing, the viewer feels as if he is seeing a moving video in slow motion. A high-speed Net connection can aid you in streaming the video live instead of capturing images and dropping them on the Web site.

FTP upload: Webcam32 (trial version available for download at www.webcam32.com) is a good broadcasting software that allows you to do FTP image uploads and even live audio-video streaming. Download the software from the site and install it. When you launch the application, it asks you to enter some details about the FTP server, username and password. If you have Web space (you need to have one for this exercise), either rented or otherwise, you can use it to upload your images. In this example we used a free FTP Web space provided by Yahoo-Geocities (ftp.geocities.com).

Before the application can actually get into action, you need to perform certain tweaks with the Webcam32 software. Enter your appropriate FTP server, username and password when prompted.

You can link the Web cam to a Web page on your site for others to see. For instance, your Web site might have a page with an image link such as `<IMG SRC=http://www.geocities.com/vidyaramanan/digit/thinkdigit.jpg>` via which your acquaintances can see your image captures through the Web camera. The command instructs the browser to fetch the image from www.geocities.com/vidyaramanan/digit. As the file `thinkdigit.jpg` on the Web site gets updated based on the upload intervals setting, the viewer will see newer images



FTP upload of images using Webcam32

every time the page refreshes. Since continuity is maintained, it will appear as if there is a live stream of video. The drawback of FTP uploading of images is the lower frame rate. You really can't have faster refreshing and uploads as it would flicker and provide very bad output to the viewer. The solution? Streaming!

Faster video via streaming: Webcam32 has the ability to camouflage itself as a Web server. Unlike the FTP uploads where a static image is stored and uploaded, in this method, an image is captured by the camera and directly delivered to the browser without waiting for a refresh time. The browser is instructed by the Webcam32 software to accept the images till it sends an end signal. Since this is a continuous process, the frame rates are better.

How exactly does this happen? Let's take an example of a link that would be available on a typical Web cam page, say, `<IMG SRC="http://www.thinkdigit.com:port/video/push">`. Here www.thinkdigit.com is the computer on which the Webcam32 software is running and port would be any number via which the software listens for requests. So when a viewer is trying to view the camera from this page, his browser is linked directly to the machine on which your Webcam32 software is running.

Network

Some popular online Web cams

<http://cn003461.phidji.com/wow/index.asp>

Launched in 1999, this site gives you single-click access to Web cams hosted across continents.

<http://www.earthcam.com>

Outdoor cams are categorised and listed alphabetically here.

<http://dsc.discovery.com/cams/cams.html>

This is Discovery channel's Web cam, which takes you into the wilder side of the world in the safety of your computer monitor.

When buying a Web cam, check for...

- ✓ **Resolution:** A camera's quality is weighed against the resolution it supports. So choose a camera with a good resolution. Most Web cams offer a resolution of 320x240, which is good enough for normal applications.
- ✓ **Connectivity:** USB connectivity, since it makes connecting a Web cam as easy as plug-and-play. Your PC needs to have a USB port too, of course.

- ✓ **FPS supported:** Watch out for the frame rates that the camera will support (at least 25 fps at 320x240). This is important or else the video quality would suffer. Dial-up users will have to bear lower frame rates.
- ✓ **Software and drivers:** Buy a camera that comes with software drivers and spare yourself a long-drawn Web hunt. Also check for bundled applications.